

Primary Source Reading 3: A Modest Proposal

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Jonathan Swift, A Modest Proposal (1729) — text unaltered A supplementary reading — a note on why it's here below

A note on this reading: Your lessons don't discuss this text yet, but a future version of the module will pair it with Lesson 13c's objections to utilitarianism. Swift's essay is satire, not moral philosophy — he proposes, with perfect economic seriousness, that Ireland's poverty could be solved by raising poor children as food for wealthy tables. No one, including Swift, thinks this is a genuine proposal. The target of the satire is a way of *reasoning*: cool, careful cost-benefit calculation applied to human beings as though they were commodities, with the human cost quietly priced out of the sum. As you read, notice how closely the structure of Swift's argument — compute the numbers, list the advantages, tally the benefits to the nation — resembles the structure of a utilitarian calculation, and ask what has gone missing from it.

The Calculation

I have been assured by a very knowing American of my acquaintance in London, that a young healthy child well nursed, is, at a year old, a most delicious nourishing and wholesome food, whether stewed, roasted, baked, or boiled; and I make no doubt that it will equally serve in a fricasee, or a ragoust.

I do therefore humbly offer it to publick consideration, that of the hundred and twenty thousand children, already computed, twenty thousand may be reserved for breed, whereof only one fourth part to be males; which is more than we allow to sheep, black cattle, or swine, and my reason is, that these children are seldom the fruits of marriage.

The Advantages, Enumerated

I think the advantages by the proposal which I have made are obvious and many, as well as of the highest importance.

Secondly, The poorer tenants will have something valuable of their own, which by law may be made liable to a distress, and help to pay their landlord's rent, their corn and cattle being already seized, and money a thing unknown.

Thirdly, Whereas the maintainance of a hundred thousand children, from two years old, and upwards, cannot be computed at less than ten shillings a piece per annum, the nation's stock will be thereby encreased fifty thousand pounds per annum, besides the profit of a new dish, introduced to the tables of all gentlemen of fortune in the kingdom, who have any refinement in taste. And the money will circulate among our selves, the goods being entirely of our own growth and manufacture.

Fourthly, The constant breeders, besides the gain of eight shillings sterling per annum by the sale of their children, will be rid of the charge of maintaining them after the first year.

After you read: Read this next to Mill's actual arguments and the resemblance is uncomfortable on purpose. Swift's narrator does exactly what a careful utilitarian calculation asks of you: he identifies everyone affected, estimates the costs and benefits to each party, and totals them into a net gain for "the nation's stock." The satire works because the arithmetic is basically sound — the horror comes entirely from what the arithmetic leaves out. When you get to Lesson 13c's objections — the justice problem, the aggregation problem, the worry that utilitarian reasoning can license using people as means to an end — keep this essay in mind. Swift is not arguing against calculation as such. He is showing what calculation looks like when it forgets that the units being summed are people.